

ITEMCASE

Community Catalog Concept

A universal collector database built by collectors - with private collections, moderated community submissions, reusable catalog records and a scalable trust system.

Core idea

Users can keep any object privately. If an item is missing from the global catalog, they can submit metadata and their own photos for review. After approval, the item becomes a reusable catalog entry for the entire ItemCase community.

Concept version: September 2026

1. Vision

ItemCase should not merely be an inventory app. The long-term product is a universal, community-maintained catalog for collectible objects. Users manage their own copies privately while the community collaboratively builds a high-quality global reference database.

Network effect

Every approved submission improves ItemCase for every future user. A catalog that begins with a few thousand records can grow into hundreds of thousands or millions of reusable collectible records without requiring the operator to enter every object manually.

The model is category-neutral. It can support trading cards, building sets, figures, steelbooks, games, comics, vinyl, coins, stamps, sneakers, model cars, books, autographs and many other collecting niches.

2. Product model

CatalogItem	Canonical product record: name, brand, category, identifiers, release data.	Public
CatalogImage	Moderated community image linked to a CatalogItem.	Public after approval
UserCollectionItem	The user's own copy: condition, purchase price, notes, quantity, location.	Private by default

This separation is fundamental. Ten thousand users who own the same product should reference one CatalogItem instead of creating ten thousand duplicate product records.

3. Submission workflow

Step 1 - Search first. Before a new item can be submitted, ItemCase searches for existing matches using name, brand, category, EAN/UPC/ISBN, manufacturer number and other category-specific identifiers.

Step 2 - Private item remains possible. A user may always create a personal item that never enters the global catalog. This allows unique, sentimental or unsuitable objects to remain in a private collection.

Step 3 - Submit for catalog review. The user provides structured metadata and preferably original front/back/detail photographs.

Step 4 - Rights confirmation. Before upload, the contributor confirms that the photographs are self-created and grants ItemCase the necessary non-exclusive rights for storage, processing, public display and commercial operation of the service.

Step 5 - Moderation. A submission is initially Pending. An administrator or trusted moderator checks identity, duplicates, image quality, obvious third-party watermarks and plausibility.

Step 6 - Publication. Approval creates or updates the canonical CatalogItem. From then on every user can add it to their collection with one tap.

Recommended status model

Private	Exists only in a user's collection.
Pending	Submitted and awaiting moderation.
Needs changes	Contributor must correct data or photos.
Approved	Published in the global catalog.
Reported	Existing catalog content is under review.
Removed	No longer publicly displayed, e.g. after a valid rights complaint.

4. Community quality system

Published records should not become immutable. Users can propose corrections, missing identifiers, additional variants and better photographs. Changes go through the same controlled review process rather than directly overwriting global data.

Contributor trust

Collector	Submit items, photos and corrections.
Contributor	Higher submission limits; contribution history visible.
Trusted Contributor	Reduced review friction for consistently accurate contributions.
Curator	Review defined categories or brands.
Moderator/Admin	Approve, merge, reject, remove and process reports.

Gamification can reward useful work without turning accuracy into a race. Useful metrics include approved first submissions, accepted corrections and approved photos. Rejected or duplicate submissions should not generate points.

5. Duplicate prevention

Duplicate control is one of the most important technical challenges in a universal catalog. ItemCase should use progressively stronger matching.

- **Exact identifiers:** EAN, UPC, ISBN, set number, manufacturer article number, card number.
- **Normalized text:** brand + product name + edition + year.
- **Fuzzy matching:** detect spelling and naming variations before submission.
- **Category-aware rules:** e.g. LEGO set number, Funko box number or trading-card set/card number.
- **Later:** perceptual image similarity to flag likely duplicates for moderator review.

6. Privacy and Collection Map

The public catalog describes a product. It must not reveal where an individual user's copy is physically stored. ItemCase's Collection Map belongs exclusively to UserCollectionItem.

Privacy principle

Public: product identity and approved catalog media. Private by default: ownership, purchase price, notes, exact storage location, collection-map hierarchy and private photographs.

Uploaded public photographs should have unnecessary EXIF metadata removed before publication, particularly geolocation metadata. Personal information visible in images should be rejected or removed during moderation.

7. Commercial model

The community catalog can remain a core product feature while Premium monetizes ItemCase's own software functionality. This keeps the value proposition focused on collection management rather than selling access to third-party franchise imagery.

Collection management	Collection analytics and advanced statistics
Catalog search	Value history / advanced value tools
Community catalog images	Cloud backup / synchronization
Owned / missing / wishlist	Multiple specialized collections
Submit items and corrections	Advanced export and reporting
Basic filters	Advanced filters and automation

8. Legal feasibility - Germany / EU

Bottom line

The business model is generally feasible for commercial operation, but community uploads do not eliminate legal responsibility. ItemCase needs a deliberately designed rights, moderation, privacy and takedown framework. A specialist review of the final terms and product presentation before launch is strongly advisable.

8.1 User photographs and copyright

The safest catalog-image model is to accept photographs that contributors created themselves. ItemCase should not assume that images found on Google, Amazon, manufacturer sites, marketplaces or fan databases can be copied commercially. The contributor should grant ItemCase an explicit license broad enough for the intended service, including public display and commercial operation.

The contributor normally remains the copyright holder; ItemCase receives usage rights. The upload terms should also define what happens if an account is deleted, whether already-published catalog images may remain, and how a contributor can raise a rights complaint.

8.2 Trademarks and product identification

A universal catalog will necessarily mention third-party brands. EU trademark law contains limitations allowing use of another party's trademark to identify or refer to the trademark owner's goods where the statutory conditions are met and the use follows honest practices. That is materially different from presenting the third-party mark as ItemCase's own brand.

Accordingly, ItemCase should use its own neutral branding, avoid implying sponsorship or affiliation, and use manufacturer/brand names primarily as factual catalog metadata. Third-party logos and franchise artwork should not be used decoratively merely because a product belongs to that brand.

Legal reference: Regulation (EU) 2017/1001, Art. 14 (limitations of the effects of an EU trade mark).

8.3 UGC and platform moderation

Once approved community submissions are made available to other users, ItemCase operates a user-generated-content service. Pre-publication moderation is valuable, but the product should still provide an accessible reporting and review process for allegedly unlawful or rights-infringing material.

The EU Digital Services Act contains rules for intermediary and hosting services, including notice-and-action mechanisms for illegal content. The precise obligations depend on ItemCase's role, size and service design. The final implementation should therefore be reviewed against the DSA before launch.

Google Play's UGC policy requires robust ongoing moderation appropriate to the type of UGC, terms/policies governing contributions and in-app mechanisms for reporting objectionable content/users where applicable. Apple's App Review Guidelines likewise impose moderation-related requirements on apps containing UGC.

8.4 Data protection

ItemCase will process account and contribution data and therefore needs a GDPR-compliant privacy design. Collect only what is needed, define purposes and retention periods, protect account data, support data-subject rights and document processors such as cloud storage, analytics and authentication providers.

For public catalog photos, stripping geolocation and unnecessary EXIF data is a sensible privacy-by-design measure. Exact physical storage information from Collection Map should never become public merely because the underlying CatalogItem is public.

8.5 Product and franchise IP

A contributor's copyright in a photograph does not automatically resolve every intellectual-property right embodied in the photographed product. Collectibles can involve trademarks, designs, artwork and fictional characters. Risk therefore varies by product and by how ItemCase presents it. A factual multi-brand catalog under an independent ItemCase identity is structurally different from building ItemCase's branding around a single third-party franchise, but it is not a blanket exemption from IP law.

9. Commercial launch safeguards

- **Independent identity:** ItemCase name, icon and visual design should not imitate a manufacturer or franchise.
- **No scraped official imagery by default:** only licensed sources or properly licensed community photographs.
- **Upload declaration:** contributor confirms authorship/right to upload and accepts the current contribution-license version.
- **Explicit commercial license:** terms cover storage, resizing/cropping, public display, distribution within the service and commercial operation.
- **Pre-publication moderation:** check duplicates, product correctness, image quality, watermarks and obvious rights/privacy issues.
- **Reporting:** every public catalog item/image should be reportable.
- **Rights-holder channel:** clear contact and documented notice/takedown workflow.
- **Audit trail:** store submission time, contributor, accepted terms version, moderation decision and change history.
- **Privacy by design:** strip unnecessary EXIF; keep collection location and personal ownership data private by default.
- **Legal pages:** imprint where required, privacy policy, terms of service, contribution terms and community/content rules.
- **Store compliance:** design moderation/reporting flows to meet current Google Play and Apple requirements before release.
- **Professional review:** have German/EU IT/IP counsel review the final upload license, terms, DSA role and trademark presentation before monetized launch.

10. Recommended architecture

CatalogItem	ID, name, brand, category, release year, identifiers, canonical metadata, status
CatalogImage	ID, CatalogItemID, contributor, URL, view/type, license version, status, moderation
UserCollectionItem	UserID, CatalogItemID or private item, condition, quantity, purchase/value data, notes, location
Submission	Submitter, proposed fields, timestamps, status, reviewer, decision, duplicate candidates
ChangeProposal	CatalogItemID, field/image change, evidence/comment, proposer, review result
Report	Target item/image, reason, reporter, status, decision, takedown history

11. Suggested rollout

MVP	Private collections + manually curated starter catalog + item submission + admin approval.
Phase 2	Community images, corrections, reports, duplicate suggestions and contribution profiles.
Phase 3	Trusted contributors/curators, category-specific schemas, stronger automated duplicate detection.
Phase 4	Large-scale catalog, value integrations, APIs/imports where licensed, advanced analytics and Premium.

Strategic result

ItemCase becomes more than a place where users type lists of possessions. The private collection layer creates daily utility; the moderated public catalog creates a durable data asset and network effect; community contribution creates scale; Premium monetizes ItemCase's own tools and analytics.

12. Key legal sources to verify at launch

- Regulation (EU) 2017/1001 on the EU trade mark - especially Art. 14.
- Regulation (EU) 2022/2065 - Digital Services Act, including notice-and-action rules applicable to hosting services.
- Regulation (EU) 2016/679 - GDPR.
- Google Play Developer Policy - User Generated Content.
- Apple App Review Guidelines - User Generated Content / safety requirements.

Important: This concept is a product and risk-design document, not individual legal advice. Exact obligations depend on ItemCase's final functionality, corporate setup, target markets, data flows and contractual wording.